then took to his bed. He emerged partially paralysed, and was believed to have suffered some kind of stroke.[3] In the days that followed, his sisters became more and more anxious, watching helplessly as their brother paced pale-faced up and down the veranda by day and lay prostrate on the lawns at night, pressing his face against the cool turf for comfort. Only a few weeks earlier, his trusted adviser Macnaghten had been writing to him from Kabul, telling him not to believe the nay-sayers and assuring him that all was well. Now his entire Imperial strategy and all his 'plans for public good and public security upon which I had staked so much have all broken under circumstances of horror and disaster of which history has few parallels'.[4] Indeed the entire catastrophe was to Auckland himself 'as inexplicable as it is appalling'. Worse still was the news that followed, that Akbar and the other leaders of the resistance were now moving to finish off the three remaining British garrisons in Jalalabad, Ghazni and Kandahar. Around India, rumours spread that, with much of the Indian army still absent in China fighting Auckland's Opium War, the Afghans would soon be pouring down the Khyber Pass to loot the plains of Hindustan as they had done so often in the past.

It was one week more before London heard what had happened. *The Times* broke the news to the nation: 'We regret to announce that the intelligence which this express has brought us is of the most disastrous and melancholy nature.' In a typically Russophobic leading article published a few days later it hinted heavily – and quite inaccurately – at a Russian hand in the events, pointing out that the first to be targeted for assassination was none other than Sir Alexander Burnes, the great rival of Vitkevitch and 'the keenest antagonist of the Russian agents'.[5]

The new Tory government of Sir Robert Peel had been all set to withdraw from Afghanistan and wash its hands of the mess created by its Whig predecessors. Now, however, it was agreed by the Cabinet that the nation's military reputation had first to be salvaged. Lord Ellenborough, the founding ideologue of the Indus policy and the man the Tories had already sent out to replace Auckland as governor general, heard of the disaster when his ship docked off Madras on 21 February. From the Governor's House he wrote immediately to Peel declaring that he intended to teach the Afghans a lesson they would never forget: 'the honour of our arms must be re-established in Afghanistan . . . Every difficulty should be encountered and overcome for the preservation of India.'[6] By the time Ellenborough